Role of women in freedom struggles

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Introduction:

✓ Women of Tamil Nadu have made significant contributions not only in politics but also across a wide range of fields including education, music, dance, sports, literature, the military, police, cinema, the freedom struggle, and social reforms.

✓ These women have not only excelled individually but also played key roles in shaping Tamil society.

✓ Their efforts highlight the vital role that women have played and continue to play in shaping Tamil Nadu's progress and identity

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Key Women Figures in Tamil Nadu's History:

Asalambikai Ammaiyar	Promoted non-violence through devotional songs like *Gandhi Puranam*, spreading Gandhian ideals.
Moovaloor Ramamirtham	Fought against the Devadasi system and founded ***Uvathi Saranalayam*** to rehabilitate exploited women
Subalakshmi	First Anthanar woman to earn a B.A.; championed widow welfare and women's education; awarded Padma Shri
Thillaiaadi Valliammai	Symbol of resistance and a fearless freedom fighter advocating for women's rights.
Ambujammal	Active in the Swadeshi movement and founder of *Sreenivasa Gandhi*, an educational center for women.
V.M. Kothainayaki Ammal	Writer and editor who used her magazine *Jeganmohini* to inform and mobilize women during the independence
K.B. Sundarambal	A famous actress and singer who joined the Salt Satyagraha and used her songs to inspire people during
T.P. Rajalakshmi	A dramatist and film star involved in the Congress and Gandhian movement, who highlighted social issues through
Nagammiar	Supported India's freedom and women's rights, working alongside her husband for social reform.
M.S.Subbulakshmi	A legendary Carnatic singer and the first musician to receive the Bharat Ratna, known for her music and charity

Fields of Contribution:

Cinema and Arts
- T.P. Rajalakshmi
- K.B. Sundarambal

Music
- M.S. Subbulakshmi

Education
- Ambujammal,
- Subalakshmi

Freedom Struggle:
- Ambujammal
- K.B. Sundarambal
- Thillaiyadi Valliammai

Social Reforms
- Moovaloor Ramamirtham
- Asalambikai Ammaiyar



Asalambikai Ammaiyar

Early Life & Background	➢ Born in 1875 in **Rendanai** Village, Thindivanam Taluk, South Arcot District, Tamil Nadu. ➢ Became active in the Indian National Movement from a young age.
Political & Social Activism	➢ Participated in **political meetings advocating for independence and social reform.** ➢ Admirer and follower of Mahatma Gandhi and his principles, especially ***Ahimsa*** (non-violence).
Notable Moment with Gandhi	➢ Honored Gandhi during his visit to **Cuddalore on September 17, 1921, on** behalf of South Arcot District Women's Fellowship.
Major Literary Work – Gandhi Puranam:	➢ Composed ***Gandhi Puranam*** – 2034 songs celebrating Gandhi's life and ideals. ➢ Completed the work at age 73; devoted 30 years to writing it.
Other Literary Contributions:	➢ ***Ramalinka Swamigal Varalatru Paadalgal*** ➢ ***Kulanthai Swamigal Pathigam*** ➢ ***Atthisoodi Venba*** ➢ ***Tilahar Puranam***
Recognition & Legacy:	➢ Called the **"Present Day Ovvaiyar"** for her literary and reformist achievements. ➢ Acknowledged in the autobiography of V. Kalyanasundaranar, a notable Tamil poet and freedom fighter.

Death	➢ Passed away in 1955.
Legacy	➢ Symbol of Tamil women's contributions to the freedom struggle and Tamil literature. ➢ Remembered for her courage, devotion, and intellectual brilliance.



Moovaloor Ramamirtham

Birth	➢ Born in **Thiruvarur in 1883.**
Social Reform Focus:	➢ Fought **relentlessly against the Devadasi system,** which exploited young girls dedicated to temples.
Organization Founded:	➢ Established **'Uvathi Saranalayam',** a welfare center for **rehabilitating Devadasis** and helping them rebuild their lives.
Literary Contributions:	➢ Wrote two novels advocating social reform: • *Thasigalin Mosavalai* (*The Web of Devadasis*) • *Mathi Petta Minor* (*The Enlightened Minor*)
Activism:	➢ Participated in the **anti-Hindi agitation of 1938.** ➢ Walked **577 miles over 42 days,** the **only woman** to show such endurance in the protest.
Legacy	➢ Died in **1962.** ➢ Remembered as a **pioneer in women's empowerment** and a key figure in the **abolition of the Devadasi system** in Tamil Nadu.



Sister Subalakshmi

Birth	➢ Born on 30 July 1886 in Mylapore, Chennai, to Subramaniya Iyer and Visalatchi Ammaiyar.
Early Education	➢ Completed primary education by the age of 9.
Marriage and Tragedy	➢ Married at 11, but her husband passed away three months later.
Determination for Education	➢ Despite opposition, continued education, and ranked third in the state matriculation exam in 1905.
Bachelor's Degree	➢ Became the first woman from the **Anthanar** (Brahmin) community to earn a B.A. degree by age 23. ➢ Started her teaching career in 1911, later becoming a headmistress.
Social Reform for Widows	➢ Focused on the plight of child widows and established **the "Shree Saratha Iyikkia Sangam"** for widows.
School for Widows	➢ Opened a school for widows in Thiruvallikeni, Chennai, with financial aid from the Tamil Nadu government. The school became the **"Lady Willington"** school in 1922.
National Recognition	➢ Awarded the **Padma Shri** by the Government of India for her contributions to women's education and social reform.
Death	➢ Passed away in 1969 at the age of 82



Thillaiaadi Valliammai

Birth	➢ Born on February 22, 1898, in **Johannesburg,** South Africa, to Tamil parents from Thillaiaadi village, near Tanjavur, Tamil Nadu.
Family Background	➢ Grew up in South Africa, where her parents had moved due to the oppressive racial policies of the British colonial government.
Inspiration from Gandhi	➢ Became inspired by Mahatma Gandhi's leadership and his fight against injustices faced by the Indian community in South Africa.
Protest Against Discriminatory Law	➢ In **1913,** the South African government passed a law declaring non-Christian or civil marriages invalid, which targeted the Indian population. ➢ Valliammai, at the **age of 16,** joined Gandhi's **non-violent protest** against this injustice.
Imprisonment	➢ Valliammai was imprisoned for participating in the protest and sentenced **to three** months in **Maritzburg Jail.**
Death	➢ While in prison, Valliammai contracted a severe fever, and despite her release, she passed away shortly after **on February 22, 1914, at the age of 16.**
Tribute by Gandhi	➢ Tamil Nadu government established a memorial statue in her honor during the celebrations of **Gandhi's silver jubilee** in 1969. ➢ In 1971, the Indian government inaugurated the **Thillaiaadi Valliammai Memorial Hall** and public library in her village. ➢ A commemorative stamp was issued in her memory on December 31, 2008.

Legacy	➢ Valliammai's courage and sacrifice continue to inspire generations in their quest for justice, freedom, and human rights.



Ambujammal

Birth	➢ Born on January 8, 1899, in Chennai, to a prominent family. ➢ Her father was **Srinivasa Iyangar, and her mother was Renganayagai Ammal.**
Education	➢ Received a well-rounded education in Tamil, English, Hindi, and Sanskrit at home.
Inspiration from Gandhi	➢ Deeply inspired by Gandhian principles from a young age. ➢ Met Mahatma **Gandhi and Kasturba Gandhi** in 1915, and was moved by Kasturba's simplicity. ➢ Donated her expensive **silk sarees and jewels to support the South African Satyagraha.**
Support for Indian Independence	➢ Actively opposed British rule by leading **boycotts of foreign goods.**
Imprisonment	➢ Arrested for her participation in protests and imprisoned in Vellore Jail, where she taught Hindi, tailoring, and flower making to fellow women prisoners.
Social Work and Education	➢ **In 1943,** became a member of the Chennai Corporation and established **the "Sreenivasa Gandhi"** women's education center, providing training in education, healthcare, and business skills. ➢ In 1945, chaired the reception committee for the **Congress conference in Avadi,** Chennai.

	➢ Founded **women's cooperative societies** in Madras to promote women's economic independence in 1946.
Chennai Social Welfare Board	➢ Served on the **Chennai Social Welfare Board** for seven years starting in 1957.
Literary Contributions	➢ Gained recognition for her writings, particularly the book ***Naan Kanda Bharatham*** **("The India I Saw").**
Awards	➢ Awarded the **Padma Shree** in **1964** for her social work.
Legacy	➢ Known for her advocacy of women's education, business development, and the abolition of the **Devadasi system.** Affectionately called the **"Adopted Daughter of Gandhiji."**



Anjalai Ammal

Birth	➢ Born in 1890 in Kadaloor, Tamil Nadu.
Role in Independence Movement	➢ Started her struggle for India's independence in **South Tamil Nadu in 1921**, becoming the first woman to do so. ➢ Actively participated in the **Non-Cooperation Movement** (1932), liquor shop protests, and **Individual Satyagraha** in 1941. ➢ Arrested multiple times and spent years in various jails, including **Kadaloor, Vellore, Trichy, and Bellari.**

Financial Sacrifice	➢ Sold all her properties to fund the struggle for India's independence.
Political Career	➢ Served as a member of the **Madras Legislative Assembly** from 1946 to 1952.
Family Involvement	➢ Encouraged her child, **Amma Kannu,** to join the freedom struggle. Amma Kannu was imprisoned for four years as a school student at the age of nine.
Death	➢ Passed away on February 20, 1961.



Kothainayaki Ammal

- December 1, 1901, in Thiruvallikeni, Chennai.
- Married at age 5, which restricted her education
- Protested against foreign clothing and liquor; was arrested for her activism.
- Advocated Gandhian principles; wore 'Kadhar' clothing
- **Titles** Known as '**Naval Rani**' (Queen of Novels) and '**Katha Mohini**' (Enchantress of Stories).



K.B. Sundarambal

- Actively participated in the **Salt Satyagraha** alongside Gandhiji, using her voice to inspire the Tamil people through songs.
- Received the **Padma Bhushan** from the central government.
- Won the **Yaelisai Vallabi Award** and **Isai Paerarinjar** Award.
- Elected to the Rajya Sabha in 1958 during Kamaraj's tenure as Chief Minister, making her the first screen star to hold a legislative position.

K.B. Sundarambal – Tamil Nadu's Cultural Legend

1. **Born on October 11, 1908,** in **Kodumudi,** near **Karur;** her name combines her village and her mother **Balambigai's** name.
2. She gained fame in **stage dramas** as a child and later became the **first Indian actress** to earn **₹1 lakh salary** for her lead role in *Nandanar*.
3. She became popular with the film *Ovviayyār* and was known for her **powerful singing and acting.**
4. **Passed away on September 19, 1980;** received a **government funeral** from then CM **M.G. Ramachandran.**

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Captain Laxmi Sehgal

- Inspired by **Bose's speech in 1943, joined efforts to form the Jhansi Rani Regiment, a women's military unit for the Azad Hind Government.**
- Donated her jewels to the Indian National Congress, inspired by Mahatma Gandhi.
- Received the **Padma Vibhushan** in 1998 for her contributions to social work
- Served as **the Women's Welfare Minister in the Azad Hind Government**
- Appointed **captain of the Jhansi Rani Regiment,** training Tamil women in military skills

Rukmini Lakshmipathi

- involvement in the **Vedaranyam Satyagraha,** becoming the first woman to be jailed for participating in the Salt Satyagraha.
- First woman **elected to the Madras Legislature.** First woman **minister in the Madras Presidency.**
- Played a key role in the **Civil Disobedience Movement** of 1930.
- Joined the **Swadeshi Movement** in the early 1920s, promoting local goods by spinning.
- Joined the Indian National Congress (INC) in 1923 and helped establish the **Congress Youth League**.
- Participant in the **Vedaranyam Salt Satyagraha** led by Rajagopalachari in Tamil Nadu

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Maniyammai

Married E.V.R. Periyar on April 9, 1949, and changed her name to **E.V.R. Maniyammai.**

After Periyar's death, she took over his responsibilities. Elected as the leader of **Dravida Kazhagam** on January 6, 1974,

Imprisoned multiple times for her advocacy of **self-respect marriage, women's rights,** and her participation in India's **freedom struggle.**



Rani Velu Nachiyar

Birth	Only child of **King Chellamuthu Vijayaragunatha Sethupathy** and **Queen Sakandhimuthathal** of the **Ramnad Kingdom,** making her the **Princess of Ramanathapuram**
First Female Freedom Fighter	Known as **Veeramangai** (meaning "brave woman" in Tamil), she is recognized as one of India's first female freedom fighters
Training	Received extensive training in various fighting techniques such as **Silambam, Valari,** horseback riding, and **archery.**

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Language Skills	Fluent in **French, English,** and **Urdu.**
Support	Received assistance from **Haider Ali,** Sultan of Mysore, including a monthly income and soldiers. • Her commander, **Kuyili,** played a crucial role in the victory against the British.
Military Strategy	Waited eight years before launching a **successful attack** against the Nawab's forces, demonstrating patience and strategic planning.